MA ENGLISH • SEMESTER 1

Block 4 — Unit 2: The Rise of the English Novel

MILTON TO THE PRE-ROMANTICS • M21EG03DC

Expanded exam notes | Simple teaching + developed argument

Based on the supplied SGOU self-learning material. Use the assigned primary texts for exact quotations and full scene or passage analysis.

The chapter in one sentence

The English novel grew through a convergence of readers, print institutions, social change, and earlier ways of narrating experience.

Start with a picture

A new kind of meal can draw on ingredients already used in several kitchens. The novel similarly develops through letters, travel, diaries, romance, journalism, spiritual autobiography, and oral narrative rather than appearing from nothing.

1. Readers and print

Publishing, bookselling, lending, literacy, and changing leisure patterns helped expand access to prose narratives. Commercial growth matters, but readership remained unequal. The relationship with industrialisation is gradual; a mature Industrial Revolution cannot explain every early-eighteenth-century novel as if it came first.

Women were readers and writers within this history, not merely an audience waiting for male authors to invent their stories.

2. Ordinary lives and realism

The novel often gives sustained attention to particular individuals, settings, objects, and sequences of experience. **Formal realism**, associated with Ian Watt’s influential account, concerns methods that present a particularised world rather than merely a choice of ordinary subject matter.

That theory is useful but not the only account of the novel’s origins.

3. Different narrative resources

Defoe uses detailed practical and providential accounts. Richardson’s letters explore inward feeling, evidence, and immediate uncertainty. Fielding’s narrators organise comic and critical distance. Smollett’s adventures and Sterne’s disruption of narrative sequence widen the possibilities further.

A **picaresque** narrative typically follows an episodic life of movement, encounters, and social exposure. Not every travel novel or story of survival fits the category equally well.

4. Clarissa as a further example

Clarissa Harlowe resists her family's marriage plans and becomes vulnerable to the manipulation and sexual violence of Lovelace. Her suffering and death prevent the narrative from offering the kind of marital reward associated with Pamela. Richardson's Clarissa uses multiple letters to expose family pressure, coercion, interpretation, and the cost of unequal authority. Its tragic outcome makes it a useful comparison with the social resolution of Pamela.

Letters provide access to competing accounts; they do not simply deliver an objective truth shared by all participants.

5. Predecessors and exclusions

Earlier prose fiction and writers such as Aphra Behn, Delarivier Manley, Eliza Haywood, and Frances Burney complicate a narrow story of a few founding men. The category novel itself has changed through criticism and publishing practices.

6. Building the argument

Give a condition, explain the opportunity it creates, and connect it to a narrative method. For example: letter culture → plausible private records → a form that organises feeling through an addressed account. Avoid a list of causes without mechanisms.

Quick check

1. Was earlier English literature without prose fiction? **No.**
2. Does realistic detail guarantee truth? **No.**
3. Is Watt's account the only possible history? **No.**

Build an exam answer

1. Identify print and readership conditions.
2. Explain older narrative resources.
3. Compare Defoe, Richardson, and Fielding through method.
4. Use Clarissa or Sterne to show diversity.
5. Qualify origin claims and include women writers.

Common mistake to avoid

Do not attribute every early novel to the effects of a later industrial society or call one work an uncontested first without defining the category.

Developed exam discussion

Practice question

Explain the rise of the novel as a convergence rather than a single invention.

Explain the argument in fuller paragraphs

The rise of the novel involves changes in production and readership together with the transformation of earlier narrative practices. Print commerce and growing literacy helped create opportunities, but no single economic event explains the form. Letters, diaries, travel accounts, spiritual narratives, and older fiction supplied techniques for making a particular life plausible and compelling.

The contrast among major novelists shows that the outcome was not one fixed formula. Defoe’s practical detail and retrospective interpretation differ from Richardson’s addressed letters, while Fielding’s overt narrative presence creates another relation to judgement. Sterne’s experiments further challenge any history that equates the novel only with transparent chronology.

A critical account must also examine its exclusions. Women’s fiction and earlier narratives complicate claims that the form begins with an uncontested first novel. Watt’s formal-realism argument is influential because it relates narrative methods to a social world, but it should be explained and evaluated rather than treated as a complete census of origins.

The strongest answer uses a few causal connections in detail. It shows how a material condition or older practice becomes a formal resource, while respecting chronology and the variety of works grouped under the later category.

Use the discussion well

Answer the exact question, not every possible topic. Make one clear point per paragraph, support it with a textual detail or a relevant classroom example, and explain its significance. Check exact quotations against the assigned text. The discussion is paraphrase and guidance, not a quotation or a guaranteed exam answer.

Textbook assignment checklist

The following numbered prompts are retained from the unit for revision. Obvious source errors are discussed in the coverage review; a prompt’s assumptions should not be accepted automatically. These are not predictions or complete written assignments.

1. Explain the reasons for describing the eighteenth century as “excellent” and “indispensable?
2. What is the story of Clarissa about?
3. Discuss the perspective that Daniel Defoe adopts to narrate his stories.
4. What is meant by a picaresque novel?
5. How did the industrial revolution enable the popularity of novels?